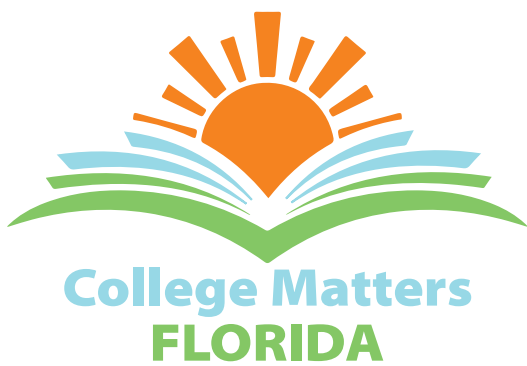




PROMISING PRACTICES

NUMBER 5

Leveraging Peer Supports to Include Students with Intellectual and/or Developmental Disabilities in Non-Academic Campus Resources: The University Participant Program at Western Carolina University

Program Background

The University Participant (UP) program at Western Carolina University (WCU) was established in 2007. WCU is located in Cullowhee, North Carolina and currently has approximately 12,000 students. Most students at WCU live in residence halls on the rural campus. The UP program uses peer supports to fully include students with intellectual and/or developmental disabilities (IDD) in non-academic activities, including residential life, student life, extracurricular activities, and overall campus membership.

Implementation

The UP program is a 2-year inclusive program for individuals with IDD between the ages of 18-25. Students with IDD live across campus and have access to all the campus offers, including the residence halls, cafeteria, clubs, and campus events. The UP program currently has over 200 peer supports, including both paid and unpaid individuals.

The UP program recruits students from designated service learning courses. Some students learn about the opportunity by word of mouth. Peer supports help students with IDD throughout their daily routines, providing support in campus life, student activities, or residential life. The UP program trains peer supports to provide assistance to peers with IDD and to know when and how to fade support. Peer supports typically work with students from 2-20 hours a week. Some peer supports are paid, usually after having worked as an unpaid peer support first.

The UP program is student-driven and has very few staff. Their staff act as coordinators, while peers serve in the support role. Graduate assistants and interns also provide assistance. Some peer supports have specific roles, such as schedulers or suitemates, while others are social supports that just “hang out” with students.

Peer supports assist with typical college activities, such as traveling on and off campus, preparing meals in the residence halls, dining on and off campus, engaging in social activities (e.g., concerts, sporting events, plays, shopping, movies), participating in clubs, and communicating safely with peers and faculty by phone, text, and social media. Other activities include community service projects, teambuilding activities, and events students plan, such as birthday celebrations.

All students access the same WCU “Engage” website to identify events of interest. Students with IDD may discuss a new event with a peer scheduler to ensure they are not overcommitted or have a conflict at that time. Peer schedulers also provide supports, including:

- jointly-created individualized and color coded schedules
- shared to-do lists with schedulers that differentiate necessary items from “wants”



This project is provided by the Florida Developmental Disabilities Council, Inc., supported in part by grant numbers 1901FLSCDD-01 and 2001FLSCDD-01 from the U.S. Administration for Community Living, Department of Health and Human Services, Washington, D.C. 20201. Grantees undertaking projects with government sponsorship are encouraged to express freely their findings and conclusions. Points of view or opinions do not, therefore, necessarily represent official ACL policy.

- reflection on the extent to which the student with IDD is meeting their goals and where there might be gaps
- communication with UP staff
- attending monthly person-centered planning meetings

In addition to supporting social activities, peer supports may assist with personal development. For example, residential suitemates help with morning and evening routines and personal care goals. Peer suitemates attend and provide input at monthly person-centered planning meetings.

Peer supports also submit weekly data about students' goal achievements to staff at the UP program. Peers discuss this data at monthly planning meetings in conjunction with program staff and the young adult with IDD.

Impact

The impact on students with IDD is meaningful and significant. Students are able to practice decision-making and greater independence within the safety of the college campus and alongside their peers. The UP program has allowed for greater student self-discovery, independence from family, and the satisfaction of trying new things that may be outside their comfort zone.

The UP program has also had a positive impact on the peer supports. For example, many peer supports have added a special education minor to their degrees and/or changed their major to inclusive education after serving as a peer support.

Though some instructors were initially resistant to the peer supports model, most are now reassured by the presence of peer supports. Education, awareness, and most of all, direct contact with students from the UP program, have positively impacted the campus community. For example, when others realize the UP student's interest and commitment, the entire classroom culture changes and expands the perceptions about who can and should attend college.

Suggestions for Replication

- **Leverage** students without disabilities to provide peer support to those with disabilities.
- **Vary peer support roles** and include scheduling specialists, suitemates, and those that support the student with IDD's engagement in the full range of typical college campus activities.
- **Incorporate** monthly planning meetings into the program to allow the student with IDD to establish social, recreational, and personal goals. This creates intentionality about how and where to engage in campus life.

For more information, please contact:

Kelly Kelley
kkelley@email.wcu.edu

or visit:
up.wcu.edu